Philosophic Society
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Reading Seminar
Industrial Society and Its Future

Editor's Note

This collection of excerpts brings together key passages from *Industrial Society and Its Future* (1995), written by math prodigy and later domestic terrorist Ted Kaczynski. The work, often referred to as the *Unabomber Manifesto*, is among the most controversial critiques of modern technology and industrial civilization. Despite the author's engagement in condemnable violence and his endorsement of violent revolution evident in some parts of this text, the diagnosis of society provided by this work remains highly thought-provoking and meaningful for the purpose of philosophical discussion. The theme of technology, progress, and human autonomy are also ever-relevant themes amidst the rise of artificial intelligence. Selected excerpts present the author's arguments on how technology has restructured social bonds, imposed artificial values, created psychological pressures, and left individuals increasingly dependent on systems beyond their control. Also, special thanks to Peter Huang for preparing the bulk of this selection.

Industrial Society and Its Future – Excerpts

INTRODUCTION

> **¶1.** The Industrial Revolution and its consequences have been a disaster for the human race. They have greatly increased the life-expectancy of those of us who live in "advanced" countries, but they have destabilized society, have made life unfulfilling, have subjected human beings to indignities, have led to widespread psychological suffering…and have inflicted severe damage on the natural world. The continued development of technology will worsen the situation. It will certainly subject human beings to greater indignities and inflict greater damage on the natural world; it will probably lead to greater social disruption and psychological suffering, and it may lead to increased physical suffering even in "advanced" countries.

SOURCES OF SOCIAL PROBLEMS

> **¶48.** It is well known that **crowding** increases stress and aggression. The degree of crowding that exists today and the isolation of man from nature are consequences of technological progress. All pre-industrial societies were predominantly rural. The Industrial Revolution vastly increased the size of cities and the proportion of the population that lives in them, and modern agricultural technology has made it possible for the Earth to support a far denser population than it ever did before. (Also, technology exacerbates the effects of crowding

because it puts increased disruptive powers in people's hands. For example, a variety of noise-making devices: power mowers, radios, motorcycles, etc. If the use of these devices is unrestricted, people who want peace and quiet are frustrated by the noise. If their use is restricted, people who use the devices are frustrated by the regulations. But if these machines had never been invented there would have been no conflict and no frustration generated by them.)

¶51. The **breakdown of traditional values** to some extent implies the breakdown of the bonds that hold together traditional small-scale social groups. The disintegration of small-scale social groups is also promoted by the fact that modern conditions often require or tempt individuals to move to new locations, separating themselves from their communities. Beyond that, a technological society HAS TO weaken family ties and local communities if it is to function efficiently. In modern society an individual's loyalty must be first to the system and only secondarily to a small-scale community, because if the internal loyalties of small-scale communities were stronger than loyalty to the system, such communities would pursue their own advantage at the expense of the system.

OVERSOCIALIZATION

¶25. The moral code of our society is so demanding that no one can think, feel and act in a completely moral way. For example, we are not supposed to hate anyone, yet almost everyone hates somebody at some time or other, whether he admits it to himself or not. Some people are so highly socialized that the attempt to think, feel and act morally imposes a severe burden on them. In order to avoid feelings of guilt, they continually have to deceive themselves about their own motives and find moral explanations for feelings and actions that in reality have a non-moral origin. We use the term "oversocialized" to describe such people.

¶26. …One of the most important means by which our society socializes children is by making them **feel ashamed** of behavior or speech that is contrary to society's expectations. … we are socialized to **conform** to many norms of behavior that do not fall under the heading of morality. Thus the oversocialized person is kept on a psychological leash and spends his life running on rails that society has laid down for him. In many oversocialized people this results in a sense of constraint and powerlessness that can be a severe hardship. We suggest that oversocialization is among the more serious cruelties that human beings inflict on one another.

HOW SOME PEOPLE ADJUST

¶84. …a **surrogate activity** is an activity that is directed toward an artificial goal that the individual pursues for the sake of the "fulfillment" that he gets from pursuing the goal, not because he needs to attain the goal itself. For instance, there is no practical motive for building enormous muscles, hitting a little ball into a hole or acquiring a complete series of postage stamps. Yet many people in our society devote themselves with passion to bodybuilding, golf or stamp-collecting. Some people are more "other-directed" than others, and therefore will

more readily attach importance to a surrogate activity simply because the people around them treat it as important or because society tells them it is important…

RESTRICTION OF FREEDOM IS UNAVOIDABLE IN INDUSTRIAL SOCIETY

¶119. …A chorus of voices exhorts kids to study science. No one stops to ask whether it is inhumane to force adolescents to spend the bulk of their time studying subjects most of them hate. When skilled workers are put out of a job by technical advances and have to undergo "retraining," no one asks whether it is humiliating for them to be pushed around in this way. It is simply taken for granted that everyone must bow to technical necessity. and for good reason: If human needs were put before technical necessity there would be economic problems, unemployment, shortages or worse. The concept of "mental health" in our society is defined largely by the extent to which an individual behaves in accord with the needs of the system and does so without showing signs of stress.

¶115. The system HAS TO force people to behave in ways that are increasingly remote from the natural pattern of human behavior. For example, the system needs scientists, mathematicians and engineers. It can't function without them. So heavy pressure is put on children to excel in these fields. It isn't natural for an adolescent human being to spend the bulk of his time sitting at a desk absorbed in study. A normal adolescent wants to spend his time in active contact with the real world.

THE POWER PROCESS

¶33. Human beings have a need (probably based in biology) for something that we will call the "power process." …The power process has four elements. The three most clear-cut of these we call **goal**, **effort** and **attainment of goal**. (Everyone needs to have goals whose attainment requires effort, and needs to succeed in attaining at least some of his goals.) The fourth element is more difficult to define and may not be necessary for everyone. We call it **autonomy**…

¶34. Consider the hypothetical case of a man who can have anything he wants just by wishing for it. Such a man has power, but he will develop serious psychological problems. At first he will have a lot of fun, but by and by he will become acutely bored and demoralized. Eventually he may become clinically depressed. History shows that leisured aristocracies tend to become decadent.…This shows that power is not enough. One must have goals toward which to exercise one's power.

Bibliography

Kaczynski, T. J. (1995, September 19). *Industrial society and its future*. The Washington Post. Retrieved November 11, 2025, from https://www.washingtonpost.com/wp-srv/national/longterm/unabomber/manifesto.text.htm

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